# Brett R. Bessen

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Comparative Political Behavior · Public Opinion · Latin America · Political Methodology

## ACADEMIC APPOINTMENTS

Assistant Professor, Tecnológico de Monterrey, 2022–Present

Visiting Scholar, University of Chicago, Chicago Center on Democracy, May 2026

## EDUCATION

PhD, Department of Political Science, University of Colorado Boulder, 2022

Concentration: Comparative politics

Dissertation: *Unbinding the Executive? Public Opinion and Presidential Accountability in Latin America*

MA, Political Science, University of Colorado Boulder, 2018

BA, Politics and Spanish, Willamette University, 2013

## PUBLICATIONS

"Social Retrospection: Conversation Networks, Performance Evaluations, and Candidate Support." *Journal of Elections, Public Opinion & Parties*, 2026.

"Restoring Institutional Confidence in Backsliding Democracies: Evidence from Mexico," with Susan Stokes and Andres Uribe. *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences*, 2025.

- Press coverage in *El Financiero*.

"Stereotypes and Scandals: Politician Gender and Public Judgments about Scandal in Mexico," with Fernanda Quintanilla Domínguez and Rebecca Bell-Martin. *Research & Politics*, 2025.

"Fairweather Cosmopolitans: Immigration Attitudes in Latin America During the Migrant Crisis," with Brendan Connell and Ken Stallman. *Latin American Politics and Society*, 2024.

"Populist Discourse and Public Support for Executive Aggrandizement in Latin America." *Comparative Political Studies*, 2024.

"Another Day, Another Currency: Self-Interest, Experience, and Attitudes Toward Dollarization in Ecuador," with Brendan Connell. *Political Behavior*, 2024.

"Rejecting Representation? Party Systems and Popular Support for Referendums in Europe." *Electoral Studies*, 2020.

## SELECTED WORKING PAPERS

Captured by the Ballot: Non-Partisan Judicial Elections and Democratic Erosion in Mexico *(Under Review)*.

Public Support for Military Governance: Evidence from Mexico. With Rebecca Bell-Martin, Daira Arana Aguilar, and Perla Paloma Lepez.

Cosmopolitanism, Messaging, and Attitudes Toward Refugees in the United States. With Brendan Connell and Ken Stallman.

Correcting Pluralistic Ignorance About Democratic Norms. With Jennifer Cole.

## TEACHING EXPERIENCE

*Tecnológico de Monterrey*:

Democratic Erosion, Fall 2025/26 & Spring 2026.

Senior Thesis Seminar, Fall 2023–25 & Spring 2023/24/26.

Experiments and Causal Inference for Public Policy, Fall 2023 & Spring 2023/24/25.

Introduction to Social Science, Fall 2023/24.

Designing and Analyzing Experiments, Faculty Workshop, Jan. 2024.

Behavioral Economics and Political Behavior, Fall 2022.

*University of Colorado Boulder*:

Applied Political Science Research, Fall 2021.

Issues in Latin American Politics, Summer 2020.

## GRANTS, FUNDING, & AWARDS

Outbound Faculty Mobility Grant, Tecnológico de Monterrey, 2026, $6,000.

Malyi Research Award, Malyi Center for the Study of Institutional and Legal Integrity, University of Chicago, with Eli Rau & Susan Stokes (PI), 2025, $10,000.

Circle of Outstanding Professors, Tecnológico de Monterrey, 2023 & 2025, $5,000.

Faculty Development Grant, Tecnológico de Monterrey, 2025, $2,300.

Malyi Research Award, Malyi Center for the Study of Institutional and Legal Integrity, University of Chicago, with Andres Uribe & Susan Stokes (PI), 2024, $10,000.

Institute for Humane Studies, 2024, $1,875.

Faculty Development Grant, Tecnológico de Monterrey, with Rebecca Bell-Martin, 2024, $3,800.

Polarization Research Lab, proposal accepted, 2023.

CU Graduate School Summer 2021 Fellowship, $6,000.

CU Boulder Graduate Student Research Grant, 2020, $3,290.

CU Boulder Graduate Student Research Grant, 2019, $3,050.

Graduate School Travel Grant, 2019, $300.

United Government of Graduate Students Travel Grant, 2019, $300.

CU Boulder Graduate Student Research Grant, 2018, $750.

Beverly Sears Graduate Student Grant, 2018, $1,000.

## INVITED RESEARCH TALKS

Captured by the Ballot: Judicial Elections and Democratic Erosion, Chicago Center on Democracy, 2026.

Can Rebuttals Restore Confidence in Eroding Democracies? Van Ek Speaker Series, University of Colorado Boulder, 2025.

Another Day, Another Currency: Self-Interest, Experience, and Attitudes Toward Dollarization in Ecuador, Escuela Superior Politécnica del Litoral (ESPOL), Ecuador, 2024.

Another Day, Another Currency: Self-Interest, Experience, and Attitudes Toward Dollarization in Ecuador, Centro de Investigación y Docencia Económicas (CIDE), 2023.

## SELECTED CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

Captured by the Ballot: Non-Partisan Judicial Elections and Democratic Erosion in Mexico. *4to Congreso Latinoamericano de Ciencias Sociales y Gobierno*, 2026.

Public Support for Military Governance: Evidence from Mexico. MPSA & APSA 2026.

Cosmopolitanism, Messaging, and Attitudes Toward Refugees in the United States. APSA 2025.

Can Rebuttals Restore Confidence in Eroding Democracies? MPSA 2024/26 & APSA 2024.

Populist Discourse and Support for Executive Aggrandizement in Latin America. The Latin American Public Opinion Project's Public Opinion and Democracy in the Americas Conference. 2023.

Fairweather Cosmopolitans: Immigration Attitudes in Latin America During the Migrant Crisis. APSA 2023.

Social Retrospection: Conversation Networks and Presidential Support in Brazil. MPSA 2023.

Elite Discourse and Support for Executive Aggrandizement in Ecuador. APSA 2022.

Unbinding the Executive: Populism, Partisanship, and Tolerance of Executive Aggrandizement in Latin America. APSA 2021.

Another Day, Another Currency: Self-Interest, Experience, and Attitudes Toward Dollarization

in Ecuador. MPSA 2021.

When Your Neighbors Are Missing: Missing Data and Imputation in Spatial Models. EPSA 2019.

Politicized Policing and Public Opinion: UK Police and Crime Commissioner Elections and Dynamic Perceptions of Crime and Immigration. MPSA 2019.

## PROFESSIONAL MEMBERSHIP & SERVICE

Coordinator (with Radha Sarkar), Departmental Research Workshop, Fall 2025–Present

Faculty Affiliate, Democratic Erosion Consortium

*Reviewer*: British Journal of Political Science, Comparative Migration Studies, Comparative Political Studies, Democratization, Latin American Research Review, Party Politics, Perspectives on Politics, Political Behavior, Politics and Governance, Revista Latinoamericana de Opinión Pública, Revista Mexicana de Opinión Pública

*Discussant/Chair*: American Political Science Association (2022–2026), Midwest Political Science Association (2023), Southern Political Science Association (2020), European Political Science Association (2019)

*Member:* American Political Science Association, Midwest Political Science Association, Southern Political Science Association, Latin American Studies Association

*CU Graduate Student Government:* President (2022), Vice President (2020), Department Representative (2019)

## UNDERGRADUATE ADVISING

Fernanda Quintanilla Domínguez
Pre-Doctoral Research Fellow, Penn Development Research Initiative

Juan Pablo Santisteban
Admitted to Yale's Master's in International and Development Economics

## TECHNICAL SKILLS

Statistical analysis (Stata, R), survey design (Qualtrics), LaTeX

## LANGUAGES

English (native), Spanish (professional fluency)

# REFERENCES

**Carew Boulding**
Professor
Department of Political Science
University of Colorado Boulder
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**Andy Baker**
Professor
Department of Political Science
Purdue University
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**Susan Stokes**
Professor
Department of Political Science
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**Gabriel Aguilera**
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